From the Afterlife

By Andrea Gibson

INTRODUCTION

Andrea Gibson, a celebrated poet and performance artist who through their verse explored gender identity, politics and their four-year battle with terminal ovarian cancer, died on July 14, 2025, at age 49. Tributes poured in from friends, fans and fellow poets who said Gibson's words had changed their lives — and, in some cases, saved them. People terminal illnesses said Gibson made them less afraid of death by reminding them that we never really leave the ones we love.

"Love Letter from the Afterlife" originally written for Gibson's wife Megan Falley, was shared online for anyone who is grieving.

Since the announcement of Gibson's death, the poem has become a spiritual farewell to readers, listeners, and loved ones. "Dying is the opposite of leaving," -- not as absence, but as presence magnified.

Love Letter from the Afterlife and Tincture by Andrea Gibson; may she rest in peace.

Tincture

Imagine, when a human dies, the soul misses the body,

actually grieves the loss of its hands

and all they could hold.

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Misses the throat closing shy, reading out loud on the first day of school.

Imagine the soul misses the stubbed toe, the loose tooth, the funny bone.

The soul still asks, Why does the funny bone do that?

It's just weird.

Imagine the soul misses the thirsty garden cheeks watered by grief.

Misses how the body could sleep through a dream.

What else can sleep through a dream?

What else can laugh?

What else can wrinkle the smile's autograph?

Imagine the soul misses each falling eyelash waiting to be a wish.

Misses the wrist screaming away the blade.

The soul misses the lisp, the stutter, the limp.

The soul misses the holy bruise blue from that army of blood rushing to the wound's side.

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When a human dies, the soul searches the universe for
something blushing,
something shaking in the cold,
something that scars,
sweeps the universe for patience worn thin,
the last nerve fighting for its life,
the voice box aching to be heard.

The soul misses the way the body would hold another
body and not be two bodies but one
pleading god doubled in grace.
The soul misses how the mind told the body,
“You have fallen from grace.”
And the body said . . .
“Erase every scripture that doesn't have a pulse.”

There isn't a single page in the bible that can wince,
that can clumsy,
that can freckle,
that can hunger.
Imagine the soul misses hunger, emptiness, rage,
the fist that was never taught to curl-curled,
the teeth that were never taught to clench-clenched,

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the body that was never taught to make love-made love
like a hungry ghost digging its way out of the grave.

The soul misses the unforever of old age,
the skin that no longer fits.
The soul misses every single day the body was sick,
the now it forced,
the here it built from the fever.
Fever is how the body prays,
how it burns and begs for another average day.

The soul misses the legs creaking up the stairs,
misses the fear that climbed up the vocal cords to curse
the wheelchair.
The soul misses what the body could not let go –
what else could hold on that tightly to everything?
What else could see hear the chain of a swing set and fall
to its knees?
What else could touch a screen door and taste lemonade?
What else could come back from a war and not come
back?
But still try to live?
Still try to lullaby?

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When a human dies the soul moves through the universe
trying to describe how a body trembles when it's lost,
softens when it's safe,
how a wound would heal given nothing but time.
Do you understand?
Nothing in space can imagine it.
No comet, no nebula, no ray of light can fathom
the landscape of awe, the heat of shame.
The fingertips pulling the first gray hair and throwing it
away.

I can't imagine it, the stars say.
Tell us again about goosebumps.
Tell us again about pain.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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Love Letter from the Afterlife

My love, I was so wrong. Dying is the opposite of leaving.
When I left my body, I did not go away.
That portal of light was not a portal to elsewhere, but a
portal to here.
I am more here than I ever was before.
I am more with you than I ever could have imagined.
So close you look past me when wondering where I am.
It's Ok. I know that to be human is to be farsighted.
But feel me now, walking the chambers of your heart,
pressing my palms to the soft walls of your living.
Why did no one tell us that to die is to be reincarnated in
those we love while they are still alive?
Ask me the altitude of heaven, and I will answer,
"How tall are you?"

In my back pocket is a love note with every word you wish
you'd said.
At night I sit ecstatic at the loom weaving forgiveness into
our worldly regrets.
All day I listen to the radio of your memories.

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Yes, I know every secret you thought too dark to tell me,
and love you more for everything you feared might make
me love you less.
When you cry, I guide your tears toward the garden of
kisses I once planted on your cheek,
so you know they are all perennials.
Forgive me, for not being able to weep with you.
One day you will understand.
One day you will know why I read
the poetry of your grief to those waiting to be born,
and they are all the more excited.
There is nothing I want for now that we are so close
I open the curtain of your eyelids with my own smile
every morning.
I wish you could see the beauty your spirit is right now
making of your pain,
your deep-seated fears playing musical chairs,
laughing about how real they are not.

My love, I want to sing it through the rafters of your
bones,
Dying is the opposite of leaving.

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I want to echo it through the corridor of your temples,
I am more with you than I ever was before.
Do you understand?

It was me who beckoned the stranger who caught you in
her arms when you forgot not to order for two at the
coffee shop.

It was me who was up all night gathering sunflowers into
your chest the last day you feared you would never
again wake up feeling lighthearted.

I know it's hard to believe, but I promise it's the truth.
I promise one day you will say it too. . .
I can't believe I ever thought I could lose you.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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